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How CEOs can Increase Public Engagement via Microblogs: The Role of CEO Gender and Content Orientation

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In the social media era, Chief Executive Officers (CEOs) are increasingly using microblogging sites to communicate with the public. Drawing on schema-congruity theory and gender egalitarianism, we investigate how CEO gender and work–life content orientation interact to influence public engagement with CEOs on microblogs. Using China as our research setting, we conduct a content analysis of data collected from 63 high-profile CEOs' microblogs and four laboratory studies with some 2000 respondents. Our results show that for female CEOs, work-related content leads to greater engagement than life-related content; for male CEOs, the effect is reversed. We find that such outcomes are driven by the incongruity between stereotypical gender roles and content orientation, which enhances perceived novelty and audience interest, thus leading to greater engagement. This effect diminishes when the audience has a very high or very low perception of gender equality in their society; or when the audience supports male privilege values personally. Our research provides new theoretical insights for online leadership communication, public engagement and gender research. It also offers useful managerial guidance for executives to effectively leverage the capabilities of social media in engaging with the public.

Introduction

Microblogging sites, such as X (formerly Twitter) and Sina Weibo, are popular communication channels for senior management, especially for Chief Executive Officers (CEOs) (Weber Shandwick, 2017). The presence of a CEO on a microblog improves his or her perceived transformational leadership abilities (Hwang, 2012) and demonstrates a more human side of the organization, in turn facilitating more direct, personal and interactive communications with the public online (Craig and Amernic, 2020; Tsai and Men, 2017). What is more, by tweeting, CEOs have an opportunity to initiate and influence online conversations with the public. Rather than waiting for impressions to be driven by the media or individuals with ulterior motives, CEOs can use microblogs to help shape the conversation (Malhotra and Malhotra, 2016).

In recent years, there has been a significant increase in the number of women assuming CEO positions (Pew Research Center, 2015). As a result, we have observed a rise in the participation of female CEOs on microblogs. For instance, in our search on Weibo, a prominent microblogging site in China, we found that out of 63 influential CEOs, 26 were female. However, little research has examined the influence of CEO gender on public engagement with microblog content. Therefore, this paper aims to bridge this research gap by investigating how the content of CEOs' microblogs affects public engagement; exploring the role of CEO gender in this process.

Regarding the content of a CEO's microblog, prior research suggests that it can be categorized according to its work–life orientation. A CEO's microblog content can be either more work-related – for example, offering business insights, advice on leadership, report-

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ing on daily work activities, business trips, corporate events, products and services, or more life-related – for example, leisure, hobbies, family, friends, seasonal greetings, daily life activities and reflections (Alghawi, Yan and Wei, 2014; Huang and Yeo, 2018; Wu *et al.*, 2022).

Schema congruity theory offers a compelling framework for our investigation into the impact of CEO gender and microblog content on public engagement. This theory, which explores the effects of congruence or incongruence between individuals' existing cognitive schemas and new information, illuminates the potential dynamics at play. Specifically, drawing on schema-congruity theory (Mandler, 1982) and gender research (Eagly and Wood, 2012; Emrich *et al.*, 2004), we conduct five studies in field and laboratory settings and find that for female CEOs, work-related content, which is less congruent with the traditional gender role (i.e. domestic for women, bread-winning for men; Eagly, 1987), triggers the public's perceived novelty of and interest in the CEO's microblog content, which, in turn, drives engagement. Notably, for male CEOs, the effect is reversed in that personal content increases engagement. This effect is moderated by the public's gender-equality perception and values.

Our research contributes to the current literature in three ways. First, by examining the relationship between gender roles, content orientation and public reactions, our study provides a better understanding of CEOs' social media communication and suggests that what to communicate (i.e. work vs personal life-related content) and who communicates it (i.e. the gender of the communicator) both matter in the social media era. Second, we incorporate gender roles into the online leadership discussion and provide novel insights into gender research in marketing. Our research shows that the traditional association of women with domestic activities and men with bread-winning work can influence the public's response to communications from a female versus a male CEO. Third, building on schema-congruity theory (Mandler, 1982) and gender egalitarianism (Emrich *et al.*, 2004), we investigate the underlying mechanism and boundary conditions for the phenomenon. As such, we provide new insights into potential drivers of online user engagement on social media, as well as extend the scope of schema-congruity theory and gender egalitarianism to corporate leader communication with the public.

As for practice, our research findings regarding the interaction effect of CEO gender and work–life content orientation provide useful implications for executives and corporate communication professionals. This is particularly relevant in light of the significant rise in the number of women occupying CEO positions in recent years (Pew Research Center, 2015).

The remainder of this paper proceeds as follows. First, we review relevant literature and develop our hypotheses. Second, we test our hypotheses by conducting five studies in field and laboratory settings. Finally, the paper concludes with theoretical and managerial implications, research limitations and directions for future research.

Theoretical framing and hypothesis development

CEO gender and gender associations

CEO gender and its impact on public response. There is a long history of leadership research on gender (Broadbridge and Hearn, 2008). Studies have found that women are considered less desirable candidates for leadership positions, and once in these positions, they are less likely to be evaluated positively relative to similarly qualified male counterparts (Eagly and Chin, 2010; Heilman, 2012; Heilman and Parks-Stamm, 2007; Joshi, Son and Roh, 2015). This may be because the communal traits (e.g. caring, interdependent, warm, emotionally sensitive) ascribed to women are less consistent with prototypical agentic leader characteristics (e.g. task-focused, ambitious, independent, rational) (Heilman, 2001; Schein, 2001). However, these effects are context-dependent and mainly observed among mid-level managers (Rosette and Tost, 2010). For example, at the uppermost levels of organizational hierarchy – such as CEOs and Chief Financial Officers (CFOs) – researchers find little evidence that female leaders are evaluated as less competent or less effective than their male peers (Paustian-Underdahl, Walker and Woehr, 2014; Rosette and Tost, 2010; Rule and Ambady, 2009; Schaumberg and Flynn, 2017). Recent evidence has revealed that female CEOs are favoured over men during crises (Ryan *et al.*, 2011); banks actively reward female entrepreneurs with privileged access to loans because they put forward more realistic and cautious funding proposals compared to hubristic male entrepreneurs (Liu and Cowling, 2023); and female executives and CEOs earn more than their male counterparts after controlling for human capital and organizational characteristics (Gayle, Golan and Miller, 2012; Hill, Upadhyay and Beekun, 2015; Leslie, Flaherty Manchester and Dahm, 2017).

Although the gender association with communal/agentic characteristics seems to have little influence on how top-level leadership are evaluated, they are still influential when it comes to CEO communication with the public. For example, Cowen and Montgomery (2020) find that following a product failure, people respond more favourably to unqualified apologies – that is, those accepting full responsibility – than other types of accommodative messages when these communications are issued by female CEOs; however, public reactions to unqualified apologies versus other types of accom-

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modative messages do not differ when these communications are from male CEOs. Cowen and Montgomery (2020) attribute such an effect to the communal norms elicited by the female CEOs, which make statements conveying an apology and accepting full blame most effective in mitigating negative public reactions.

Traditional gender-role associations with work–life activities. Gender association with communal/agentic characteristics is considered to stem from the traditional division of labour – women have been disproportionally observed as performing the majority of domestic activities, such as childcare, cooking and sewing, while men have more continuous employment with longer hours and higher wages. Although women's participation in the workforce has increased in the past 30 years (Eagly and Wood, 2018; Ortiz-Ospina, Tzvetkova and Roser, 2018; U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2018), women are still frequently associated with wifely and maternal duties, and men with competing in the workplace (Eagly *et al.*, 2020; Haines, Deaux and Lofaro, 2016; Heilman, 2012).

If we consider that beliefs about women being communal and men being agentic can influence how the public react to messages communicated by female versus male CEOs, it is reasonable to assume that the traditional gender association of women with domestic activities and men with bread-winning work, which contributes to gender-stereotypical beliefs, can also impact the public's response to CEO communications. However, there is a lack of research investigating such impact. Therefore, this paper aims to fill this research gap by examining how CEO gender, specifically the traditional gender association with work–life activities, influences the public's response to CEO communication on microblogs.

CEO communication on microblogs: work versus private-life content

As of the third quarter of 2023, the average monthly active user base of X (formerly Twitter) and Sina Weibo, two of the largest social networking and microblogging service sites, has reached 666 million and 605 million, respectively (Statista, 2023; Weibo, 2023). Many CEOs are using microblogs to interact, create dialogues and build relationships with the public. This has led to a call for a new type of leader – namely a 'Chief Engagement Officer', a term coined in the 2014 Edelman Trust Barometer to emphasize CEOs' engagement responsibility in the social media age.

The CEO's new role as corporate ambassador in engaging the public represents an emerging research domain. Researchers have shown interest in deciphering the nature and content of CEO social media communication. Current research suggests that CEOs' microblog content can be classified according to their work–life orientation. For example, Jameson (2014) categorizes CEO microblog communication into professional, which arises from a person's work, vocation or organizational roles, and personal, which arises from other roles and contexts. Similarly, Huang and Yeo's (2018) study analyses 1068 original tweets from Fortune 1000 CEOs and finds that one key communication goal for CEOs using microblogs is to update either their work or personal-life status. Moreover, based on a content analysis of more than 65,000 tweets by 338 CEOs, Wu *et al.* (2022) suggest that a CEO's microblog content can be either more work-related or more life-related. The former covers topics such as business insights, advice on leadership, daily work activities, business trips, corporate events and products and services, whereas the latter includes non-work-related topics ranging from leisure, hobbies, family, friends and seasonal greetings to daily activities and reflections.

Given the traditional association of women with domestic activities and men with bread-winning work, incongruity may arise when a female CEO predominantly discusses her work over her personal life, and conversely, when a male CEO speaks more about his personal life than his professional duties. According to Mandler's (1982) schema-congruity theory, new information aligned with existing knowledge structure is deemed schema-congruent, while new information that does not align with an existing semantic network is considered incongruent. When schema incongruity is encountered, the novelty of the information may increase interest and is likely to prompt extensive cognitive elaboration. The process of resolving the incongruity is considered rewarding and therefore may lead to a positive response (Meyers-Levy and Tybout, 1989).

The effects of schema incongruity have received extensive support in the marketing communication literature (e.g. Chun *et al.*, 2015; Gerrath and Biraglia, 2021; Wang and Liu, 2020). In this paper, we extend the application of schema congruity to corporate leader communication by studying the effect of gender-role incongruent CEO microblog content on public engagement.

Engagement with CEO microblogs

User engagement has been the focus of attention for management researchers in the social media age. Indeed, social media has enabled companies to constantly interact and build relationships with the public, including current and potential customers and investors (Lemon and Verhoef, 2016; Van Doorn *et al.*, 2010; Verhoef, Reinartz and Krafft, 2010).

Scholars are generally in consensus that engagement comprises three dimensions – cognitive, affective and behavioural (Dessart, Veloutsou and Morgan-Thomas, 2016; Dwivedi, 2015; Hollebeek, Glynn and Brodie,

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2014; Pansari and Kumar, 2017; So *et al.*, 2016; Zhang, Kandampully and Bilgihan, 2015). Cognitive engagement often connotes the mental states that a user experiences, such as attention and absorption; affective engagement refers to emotional reactions, such as enthusiasm and enjoyment; whereas behavioural engagement is generally defined as behavioural manifestations towards the engagement partner beyond the purchase. In particular, Khan (2017) distinguishes between two forms of engagement on social media: consumption (i.e. viewing and reading content) and participation (i.e. liking, commenting and sharing of such content). In this paper, we focus on the participation aspect of behaviour engagement. These behavioural aspects are considered as more practical, offering more actionable insights and being in line with predominantly used social media communication (e.g. Dhanesh, Duthler and Li, 2022; Dhaoui and Webster, 2021; Giakoumaki and Krepapa, 2020; Malhotra, Malhotra and See, 2013; Men *et al.*, 2018; Yue *et al.*, 2019). As this study seeks to extend insights on social media communication, we conceptualize and define public engagement with CEOs on microblogs as the liking, commenting and sharing of content posted by CEOs on the microblog.

Recent research suggests that incongruent and non-conventional content is an important driver of user engagement. For example, Ashley and Tuten (2015) find that creative content such as experiential, image and exclusivity messages enhances user engagement on social media. Boukes *et al.* (2022) analyse the social media posts of a wide variety of American TV shows on Facebook, YouTube and X (formerly Twitter), and reveal that the satire genre is more likely to evoke user-content interactivity than regular news and partisan news shows. Wang and Liu (2020) show that less congruent brand extensions can lead to superior evaluations when consumers perceive strong conceptual competence in the brand. Chun *et al.* (2015) suggest that consumers evaluate low-fit extensions of brands with strong reputations more favourably if innovative brand benefits are presented. Moreover, Gerrath and Biraglia (2021) find that an announcement of a new product with less congruence with the brand leads to greater consumer engagement with the posted announcement on social media. Therefore, we propose that content incongruent with traditional gender roles – such as messages with work-related (vs private life-related) content posted by a female (vs male) CEO – may be particularly engaging in the social media environment.

H1: CEO gender and content orientation of the CEO's post have an interaction effect on public engagement with microblogs. (a) For female CEOs, work-related content leads to greater public engagement than life-related content. (b) For male CEOs, life-related content leads to greater public engagement than work-related content.

The mediation role of perceived novelty and interest

Traditions play a crucial role in shaping individuals' schemas, which are the mental representations of their experiences stored in memory (Strauss, 1992). When a stimulus or an event does not align with one's existing mental categories or schemas, it is perceived as novel (Förster, Marguc and Gillebaart, 2010). In our daily lives, terms like 'new' or 'unusual' are commonly used to describe novelty. As highlighted earlier, there exists a traditional association of women with domestic activities and men with bread-winning work. Consequently, when a female (resp. male) CEO showcases a greater (resp. lesser) emphasis on their work rather than their personal life, it may be unexpected and perceived as novel due to the incongruity with conventional gender stereotypes.

Novel events or stimuli can inspire interest in the content (Berlyne, 1960; Bohme, 1980; Burke and James, 2008). Interest is generally defined as a psychological state that emerges from a person's interaction with an object or environment (Krapp *et al.*, 1992). Interest can be either personal – that is, a person's relatively long-term preference in something (Ainley, 2012; Ainley and Hidi, 2014; Krapp and Prenzel, 2011; Schiefele, 2009) or situational – that is, triggered by certain stimuli where a person feels interested in something at a particular time (Hidi, 2006; Hidi and Renninger, 2006; Schraw and Lehman, 2001). The latter has received extensive academic attention, with an effort to understand individuals' situational interests and identify potential interest triggers. One key trigger that has been frequently proposed for situational interest is novelty. For example, Berlyne (1960, 1971, 1974) was among the first researchers to consider stimuli-based causes of interest. He concludes that interest is a function of collative variables such as novelty, surprisingness, unexpected events and/or ideas. Anderson *et al.* (1987) and Deci (1992) also suggest novelty as a key component that leads a person to a psychological state of being interested in a piece of text or an activity.

Novel and interesting content has been frequently identified as a major driver of user engagement on social media. For example, Stathopoulou *et al.* (2017) suggest that topics of shared interest by the brand and the consumer lead to greater engagement. Dolan *et al.* (2016) posit that informative, relational or entertaining content drives engagement. Borah *et al.* (2020) show that marketing content characterized by humour and unanticipated content positively affects online 'virality', such as sharing and conversations about the brand. These results are consistent with research on word-of-

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mouth and sharing behaviour showing that atypical and surprising content tends to be favoured and become more popular (Berger and Packard, 2018); original and interesting products tend to bring higher levels of word-of-mouth (Berger and Schwartz, 2011; Moldovan, Goldenberg and Chattopadhyay, 2011); sharing unusual content may reflect positively on the sharer of such information (De Angelis *et al.*, 2012).

Therefore, we propose that the traditional gender role-incongruent content would enhance the perception of novelty and interest, and ultimately engagement. That is, when a female CEO posts work-related content or a male CEO posts life-related content, the public will be more likely to perceive the content as novel, which will trigger stronger interest, thus leading to greater engagement with the CEO on the microblog.

H2: The interaction effect between CEO gender and content orientation on public engagement is mediated by the perception of novelty and the resulting interest in the content.

The moderating role of gender-equality perception and values

Drawing on gender-equality research, we propose that the public's gender-equality perception and values serve as moderators for how CEO gender and content orientation interact to affect public engagement. Gender equality, or gender egalitarianism, describes the extent to which members' biological sex determines the roles that they play in their home, business organization and communities (Emrich *et al.*, 2004). Societies with greater gender equality rely less on members' sex in determining the allocation of roles between the sexes. For instance, low gender-egalitarian societies are characterized by traditional gendered division of labour, such that men are viewed as breadwinners and women are viewed as caretakers and mothers; whereas in high gender-egalitarian societies, there is less compliance to these traditional gender-role prescriptions and more similarity in women's and men's involvement in work and non-work domains (Emrich *et al.*, 2004).

According to Emrich *et al.* (2004), gender egalitarianism is comprised of two elements: (1) people's perception of the current degree of gender equality in their societal practice (GEP), such as whether they agree or disagree that in their society men and women have equal chance of finding a job; and (2) people's values regarding gender equality (GEVs), such as whether they agree or disagree that in their society men and women *should* have an equal chance of finding a job.

An individual's perception of GEP may influence their perception of novelty of gender role-incongruent content on CEO microblogs. Specifically, those who perceive high, moderate or low levels of GEP may, in turn, weakly, moderately or strongly link gender to traditional roles. Consequently, they may find a female (resp. male) CEO's focus on work (resp. life) on microblogs to be varying in degrees of novelty, ranging from not novel to moderately novel, to highly novel.

According to schema-congruity theory, increased novelty does not always evoke more favourable responses. In fact, there is an inverted-U relationship between perceived schema incongruity and affect, wherein moderate levels of incongruity lead to more favourable responses than either extreme congruity or incongruity (Mandler, 1982; Meyers-Levy and Tybout, 1989). This is consistent with the well-known 'MAYA' (Most Advanced, Yet Acceptable) principle from Raymond Loewy (Raymondloewy.com, 2023) regarding new product evaluations: people can easily get bored with new products that are congruent with their expectations, but they can also reject products that are too incongruent with their expectations – too much incongruity can be difficult to resolve, thus resulting in negative affect such as anxiety and frustration. In contrast, moderate incongruity, offering a balance of novelty, tends to be engaging and easier to integrate into existing schemas, potentially leading to positive reactions such as curiosity and interest (Berlyne, 1966; Goodstein, 1993; Mandler, 1982; Noseworthy, Di Muro and Murray, 2014).

Therefore, we propose that while moderate GEP fosters an optimal level of perceived novelty, enhancing interest and engagement, perceptions of GEP that are either very high or very low diverge from this balance. In these instances, interest and engagement may not increase as significantly as they do with moderate GEP, because the resulting level of perceived novelty becomes either too low, potentially leading to boredom, or too high, which could be overwhelming.

H3: The interaction effect of CEO gender and content orientation on perceived novelty will be diminished when the public perceive a *very high* level of GEP.

H4: The interaction effect of CEO gender and content orientation on public interest (a) and engagement (b) will be diminished when the public perceive a *very high* or *very low* level of GEP.

Next, we further propose that whether moderate novelty ultimately leads to engagement also depends on the person's GEVs. Regarding individuals' personal GEVs, there are three groups: (1) individuals who believe in female privilege, that is, there should be preferential treatment of women in society (e.g. women should have a greater chance of finding a job than men); (2) people who believe in gender equality, that is, opportunities should be equally available for men and women (e.g. men and women should have an equal chance of finding a job); and (3) those who believe in male privilege, that is, opportunities should be more available for men than

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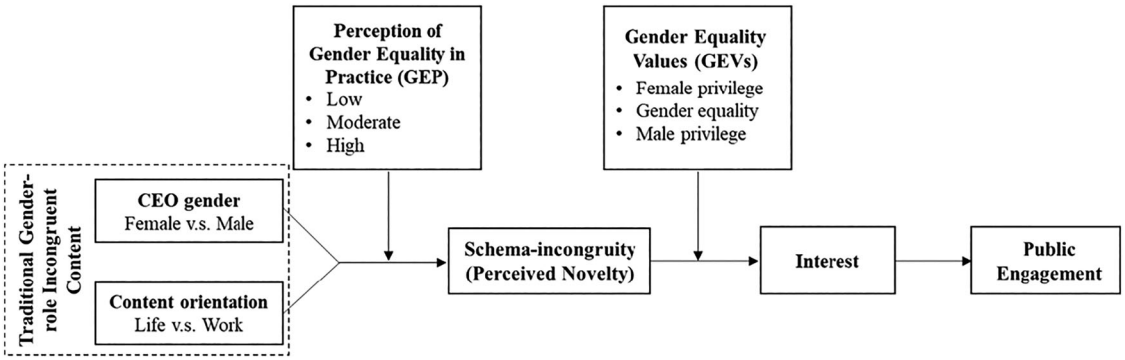


Figure 1. Conceptual model

for women (e.g. men should have a greater chance of finding a job than women) (Emrich *et al.*, 2004; House *et al.*, 2004).

We postulate that individuals who advocate for female privilege or uphold gender equality values are more receptive to content that is incongruent with traditional roles, viewing it as an opportunity to promote broader societal progress towards equality. In contrast, those who subscribe to male privilege values might find content that deviates from traditional gender norms more provocative, as it conflicts with their established values, potentially reducing their interest and engagement.

H5: The interaction effect of CEO gender and content orientation through perceived novelty on public interest (a) and engagement (b) will be diminished when the public support male privilege values.

Our hypotheses are illustrated in Figure 1.

Below we test the developed hypotheses empirically, using China as research context. Study 1 is a content analysis of data collected from 63 high-profile social CEOs' microblogs aimed at testing the interaction effect of CEO gender and content orientation on public engagement. To enhance internal validity, Study 2 tests the above effect in a laboratory setting. The mediating roles of perceived novelty and interest are examined in Study 3. Studies 4 and 5, respectively, verify the proposed moderating roles of perceived GEP and GEVs.

Study 1

Study 1 aims to test the interaction effect of CEO gender and content orientation on public engagement (H1). Specifically, we expect that for a female CEO, work-related content leads to greater public engagement than life-related content, and such an effect would be reversed for a male CEO.

CEO Weibo sampling and coding

Weibo was selected as our data collection platform. As a leading microblogging site in China, one of the most active microblogging markets in the world, Weibo had 605 million monthly active users and 260 million daily active users as of September 2023 (Weibo, 2023). Many users follow popular business leaders in the country. For example, Ms Lan Yang, co-founder and chairperson of Sun Media Group and Mr Jun Lei, billionaire entrepreneur and CEO of Xiaomi, are two of the well-recognized corporate leaders on Weibo, with over 40 million and 23 million followers, respectively.

To the best of our knowledge, there is no Weibo CEO list available in either the academic or the practitioner literature. Thus, we adopted a grounded approach to identify CEOs on the platform by using Forbes lists and Weibo search queries.

First, we referred to a number of Forbes lists, including Forbes China's Best CEOs 2021, Forbes China's 100 Richest 2021, Forbes China's Top 100 Businesswomen 2022, Forbes Under 30s – China 2021. A search was conducted on Weibo for a verified account[1] under the CEO's name with his/her identity as a CEO displayed in the profile. This process enabled us to identify 31 CEOs (11 female, 20 male) on Weibo.

Second, multiple search queries were also conducted using keywords such as CEO, founder, chairperson and general director. Weibo was able to classify users by their gender and to return a list of either female or male users whose profile information included the specified keywords. Names on the first two results pages of each search query were collected, yielding an initial list of 309 (159 female, 150 male) 'potential CEOs', that is, users who described themselves as CEOs or top executives of a certain brand. Among these users, those with a ver-

[1] An account with a 'V' badge on Weibo is a verified account.

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ified account and brand[2] with over 1 million followers were included into our sample. This yielded 32 additional CEOs (15 female, 17 male) for our research.

Therefore, by referring to Forbes lists and using Weibo search queries with keywords, we identified a total of 63 CEOs (26 female, 37 male) on Weibo (see Online Appendix 1 for full lists). A random sampling method was then used to collect 30 posts from each CEO account over the last 6 months. Note that for CEOs who posted fewer than 30 times during the targeted timeframe, all of their posts were included in the sample. After filtering out posts that mention celebrity endorsers with a huge fan base or Weibo auto-created content (i.e. announcing the birthday of the CEO), our final sample consisted of 1384 posts and the associated Weibo metrics (numbers of likes, comments and shares) from 63 high-profile Weibo CEOs.

One of the study authors and a research assistant served as coders. Posts with work-related content, such as business insights, advice on leadership, daily work activities, business trips, corporate events, products and services, were coded as 1; life-related content, such as leisure, hobbies, family, friends, seasonal greetings, daily life activities and reflections, was coded as 0. To ensure inter-rater reliability, the two coders categorized 50 posts independently. The categorizations were then compared, with differences discussed and definitions updated. Each coder then encoded the rest of the post independently. The intercoder reliability ($\alpha = 0.91$) and agreement ($\kappa = 0.84$) indicated a high reliability and agreement between coders.

Model specifications

We define our model as

$$\text{Engagement}_i = \alpha + \beta_1 Gender_i + \beta_2 Cont_i + \beta_3 Gender_i Cont_i + \beta'_4 Ctrl_i + \varepsilon_i$$

where i represents the CEO, Gender stands for CEO gender (0 = female, 1 = male), Cont for content orientation (0 = life, 1 = work) and Ctrlt_i for all control variables, that is, follower count, CEO years on Weibo, CEO age, post count, day count since the post was published, post length, media richness (whether the post has attached an image, video or web link), industry and CEO-specific fixed effects.

Accordingly, when Gender = 0 (female CEOs), the coefficient β_2 for Cont represents the effect of content orientation on Engagement. If $\beta_2 > 0$, it suggests that for female CEOs, work-related content leads to greater engagement than life-related content, thus supporting H1a. When Gender = 1 (male CEOs), the coefficient β_2 for Cont and the coefficient β_3 for GenderCont combine to indicate the influence of content orientation on Engagement. Therefore, if $\beta_2 + \beta_3 < 0$, that suggests for male CEOs, work-related content leads to lower engagement than life-related content, thus supporting H1b.

Results

Our sample consisted of 1384 posts from 63 high-profile Weibo CEOs. There were 641 posts (46.32%) from female CEOs and 743 posts (53.68%) from male CEOs. The CEOs had an average of 4.99 million followers and had published an average of 313 posts (SD = 1260) during the last 6 months. They had an average age of 45 years and 12 years of experience in using Weibo. Regarding post content, the CEOs are slightly more work-oriented ($M_{prof} = 0.59$).

We explored the impacts of CEO gender and content orientation on engagement using hierarchical regression analyses, controlling follower count, CEO years on Weibo, CEO age, post count, day count since the post had been published, post length, media richness, industry and CEO-specific fixed effects. Because of the large variances in the dependent variables, normality of the residual distribution was checked and revealed significant positive skewness and kurtosis. To address this issue and meet the normality assumption of regression, natural log transformation was utilized on the outcome variable (i.e. number of likes, comments and shares) prior to fitting linear regressions. Log transformation is a technique commonly used to transform skewed data to approximately conform to normality (Benoit, 2011; Men *et al.*, 2018). Engagement was thus measured by averaging the natural log of likes, comments and shares. The residuals in the linear regression models were rechecked and met the normality assumption of regression analysis. Besides, the collinearity test showed that all VIF < 10.

We conducted four models. Model 1 included only the variables of interest, namely CEO gender, content orientation and their interaction term. Models 2–4 incorporated blocks of control variables. As shown in Table 1, across all models, the main effect of content orientation is consistently significantly positive (all $p < 0.05$), suggesting that for female CEOs (Gender = 0), work-related content increases engagement. A post-hoc analysis of covariance (ANCOVA) of model 4, which included all control variables, further shows that when a female CEO tweets, the public are likely to be engaged more with work-related posts than life-related content ($M_{life} = 3.35$, $M_{work} = 4.11$, $F(1, 1316) = 29.80$, $p < 0.001$), therefore supporting H1a. Furthermore, across all models, the interaction effect of CEO gender and content orientation is significant (all $p < 0.001$), with

[2]The brand stated in the profile should have an authentic official website/app or should have been mentioned by a trustworthy media outlet.

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Table 1. Study 1 regression analysis results

	Engagement							
	Model 1		Model 2		Model 3		Model 4	
Predictors	SE	t	SE	t	SE	t	SE	t
CEO gender	0.22***	5.12	0.17***	4.12	0.28***	6.69	0.18***	2.70
Content orientation	0.17***	4.21	0.09**	2.40	0.11**	3.16	0.18***	5.46
Interaction	−0.30***	−5.93	−0.23***	−4.92	−0.32***	−7.49	−0.37***	−9.00
Follower count			0.30***	10.99	0.23***	7.82	0.04	1.01
CEO years on Weibo			0.09***	3.38	0.03	1.29	0.02	0.66
CEO age			−0.19***	−7.13	−0.36***	−11.51	−0.25***	−5.64
Post count			−0.02	−0.75	0.09***	3.63	0.17***	6.17
Day count			0.02	0.89	0.01	0.67	0.42	1.01
Post length			0.16***	5.96	0.18***	7.28	0.17***	7.90
Media richness			0.03	1.10	0.05*	1.92	0.08***	3.66
Industry					Controlled		Controlled	
CEO							Controlled	
R^2	0.03		0.16		0.36		0.57	
ΔR^2			0.13***		0.20***		0.21***	

*p < 0.1. **p < 0.05. ***p < 0.001.

Notes: (1) Log_Shares is obtained by natural log transformation of (number of shares + 1) to include posts with 0 shares into the regression. The same procedure is applied to obtain Log_Comments and Log_Likes. (2) Engagement is obtained by averaging Log_Shares, Log_Comments and Log_Likes. (3) Media richness is obtained by checking if a post has attached an image, video or web link. (4) Industries are classified according to the Industry Classification Benchmark – Globe Classification System (FTSE). A dummy variable is created for each industry to account for the fixed effects of the industries. (5) A dummy variable is created for each CEO to account for the fixed effects of the CEOs.

$\beta_2 + \beta_3 < 0$. A follow-up ANCOVA of model 4 – the full model – suggests that for male CEOs, life-related content is likely to generate greater engagement ($M_{life} = 4.31$, $M_{work} = 3.62$, $F(1, 1316) = 52.47$, $p < 0.001$), thus supporting H1b. Therefore, H1 is supported.

Study 2

To enhance the internal validity of Study 1, Study 2 was conducted in a laboratory setting, testing again H1, that is, whether CEO gender and content orientation interact in influencing engagement.

Study 2 used a 2 (CEO gender: female vs male) × 2 (content orientation: life vs work) between-subject design. An online experiment was run on Surveystar,[3] a large Chinese survey and experiment website. A total of 238 Chinese respondents (99 women, 139 men) participated in the study for a payment of RMB 6 (∼ USD 1) and a chance to win a prize from a lucky draw sponsored by the website. The average age of the participants was 31 years (see Online Appendix 2 for details on design and procedure, including manipulation checks and reliability checks).

An ANOVA of engagement as a function of gender and content orientation, controlling for participant gender, yielded a significant two-way interaction ($F(1, 233) = 27.29$, $p < 0.001$). For female CEOs, work-related content led to greater engagement ($M = 5.24$) than life-related content ($M = 4.25$, $p < 0.001$), supporting H1a; whereas for male CEOs, the effect is reversed – the audience indicated greater engagement with life-related content ($M = 5.08$) than work-related content ($M = 4.63$, $p = 0.02 < 0.05$), supporting H1a. Therefore, H1 is supported.

Study 3

The purpose of Study 3 is to test our proposed mediation path: the interaction between CEO gender and content orientation would result in perceived schema incongruity (novelty), which would enhance interest, thus boosting the public's engagement with the CEO microblog (H2).

A total of 272 Chinese participants (182 women, 90 men) were recruited on the Surveystar website for a payment of RMB 6 (∼ USD 1) and a chance of winning a lucky draw. The average age was 38. Participants were randomly assigned to one of 2 (CEO gender: female vs male) × 2 (content orientation: life vs work) conditions of a between-subject design (see Online Appendix 2 for details on design and procedure, including manipulation checks and reliability checks).

An ANOVA, controlling for participant gender, suggests a significant two-way interaction between content orientation and CEO gender ($F(1, 267) = 17.97$, $p < 0.001$). In particular, for female CEOs, work-related

[3]Surveystar (previously Sojump): http://wjx.cn, similar to platforms such as MTurk and Prolific Academic, predominantly consists of Chinese users.

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content generated greater engagement (M = 4.95) than life-related content (M = 4.35, p = 0.01 < 0.05); whereas for male CEOs, the effect is reversed – the audience were engaged more with life-related content (M = 4.96) than work-related content (M = 4.16, p < 0.001). These results reaffirm our findings in Studies 1 and 2, supporting H1.

A mediation analysis was then conducted using the PROCESS macro with 5000 bootstrapping (Model 83; Hayes, 2018). As expected, the interaction between CEO gender and content orientation was a significant predictor of perceived novelty ($\beta = -1.02$, t = −3.30, p = 0.0013 < 0.05). Furthermore, perceived novelty had a significant effect on interest ($\beta = 0.60$, t = 14.72, p < 0.001). For engagement, both perceived novelty ($\beta = 0.36$, t = 6.61, p < 0.001) and interest ($\beta = 0.61$, t = 10.10, p < 0.001) have a significant effect on engagement. Of central importance, the bias-corrected bootstrapping analysis supported the proposed sequential mediation: CEO gender × content orientation → novelty → interest → engagement. In particular, for female CEOs, the indirect effects of content orientation on engagement through perceived novelty and then interest were significantly positive, with 95% CI [0.01, 0.33]; for male CEOs, the indirect effects of content orientation on engagement through perceived novelty and subsequently interest were significantly negative, 95% CI [−0.40, −0.04]. Therefore, H2 was supported.

Study 4

We propose two boundary conditions for the interaction effect of CEO gender and content orientation on public engagement: the public's perception of GEP and their personal GEVs. Study 4 is to verify the first boundary condition, that is, perceived GEP.

Study 4 adopted a 3 (perceived gender equality in practice: low vs moderate vs high) × 2 (CEO gender: female vs male) × 2 (content orientation: life vs work) between-subject design. A total of 771 Chinese participants (437 women, 334 men, $M_{age} = 32$) were recruited on Surveystar for a payment of RMB 7 (∼ USD 1.04) and a chance of winning a lucky draw (see Online Appendix 2 for details on design and procedure, including manipulation checks and reliability checks).

A three-way ANOVA, controlling for participant gender, was conducted to examine the impact of GEP, CEO gender and content orientation on perceived novelty, public interest and engagement. The results of the pairwise comparison analysis, presented in Table 2, revealed significant interaction effects between CEO gender and content orientation on perceived novelty, public interest and engagement when participants perceived a moderate level of GEP. Specifically, when female CEOs posted work-related content, it generated greater perceived novelty, public interest and engagement compared to life-related content. In contrast, male CEOs generated greater perceived novelty, public interest and engagement with life-related content compared to work-related content.

Table 2. Study 4 results

GEP	CEO gender	Mean difference (work–life)		
		Novelty	Interest	Engagement
Low	Female	0.46**	0.18	0.00
	Male	−0.48**	−0.32	−0.41
Moderate	Female	0.56**	0.48**	0.64**
	Male	−0.58**	0.68**	−0.74**
High	Female	0.02	0.02	0.30
	Male	−0.04	0.02	−0.27

*p < 0.1. **p < 0.05. ***p < 0.001.
Note: Participant gender has been included as a covariate across all models.

However, for participants with a high level of GEP, the interaction effect between CEO gender and content orientation on perceived novelty, interest or engagement was not significant. This indicates that participants did not find it particularly novel when a female (or male) CEO posted work-related (or life-related) content, resulting in no significant interest or engagement.

It is important to note that although participants in the low gender-equality perception group perceived significant differences in novelty between the work-related and life-related content posted by female or male CEOs, they did not feel interested or engaged with this method of microblogging. In other words, while they acknowledged the novelty of a female (or male) CEO focusing more on work (or life), it did not generate interest or engagement among participants.

These results support H3 and H4 regarding the moderating effect of GEP on novelty, interest and engagement.

Study 5

The purpose of Study 5 is to verify the second proposed boundary condition, that is, personal GEVs, for the interaction effect of CEO gender and content orientation on engagement.

Study 5 employed a between-subject design, consisting of three factors: GEVs with three conditions (female privilege, gender equality and male privilege), CEO gender with two levels (female and male) and content orientation with two levels (life and work). A total of 770 Chinese participants (391 women, 379 men, $M_{age} = 33$) were recruited through Surveystar and offered compensation of RMB 10 (∼ USD 1.48) along with a chance to win a lucky draw (see Online Appendix 2 for details on de-

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Table 3. Study 5 results

GEVs	CEO gender	Mean difference (work–life)		
		Novelty	Interest	Engagement
Female	Female	0.39*	0.47**	0.57**
	Male	−0.43**	−0.42*	−0.60**
Equal	Female	0.57**	0.54**	0.39*
	Male	−0.36*	−0.60**	−0.41*
Male	Female	0.42**	0.19	0.34
	Male	−0.45**	−0.30	−0.18

*p < 0.1. **p < 0.05. ***p < 0.001.
Note: Participant gender has been included as a covariate across all models.

sign and procedure, including manipulation checks and reliability checks).

To explore the influence of GEVs (gender equality values), CEO gender and content orientation on perceived novelty, public interest and engagement, an ANOVA, controlling for participant gender, was conducted. The results from the pairwise comparison analysis (presented in Table 3) indicated significant interaction effects between CEO gender and content orientation in relation to perceived novelty, public interest and engagement among participants who embraced non-male (i.e. female or equal) privilege values. Specifically, when female CEOs shared work-related content, it evoked a greater sense of novelty, public interest and engagement compared to life-related content. Conversely, for male CEOs, life-related content elicited higher levels of perceived novelty, public interest and engagement in comparison to work-related content.

Interestingly, among participants who held male privilege values, there were significant differences in perceived novelty when exposed to work-related and life-related content from female and male CEOs. However, despite these perceived differences, they did not express a substantial level of interest or engagement with this particular microblogging approach. In other words, while participants acknowledged the novelty associated with a female (or male) CEO focusing more on work (or life), it did not translate into notable interest or engagement.

These results support H5 on the moderating effect of GEV on public interest and engagement.

Discussion

Drawing on schema-congruity theory (Mandler, 1982) and gender egalitarianism (Emrich *et al.*, 2004), this study examines the interaction effects between CEO gender and work–life content orientation on public engagement. Based on an analysis of 1384 microblog posts of 63 high-profile CEOs and four laboratory studies, we find that for female (resp. male) CEOs, work-related (resp. life-related) content leads to perceived novelty and interest, which in turn drives engagement. Note that this effect diminishes when the public have a very high or very low perception of gender equality in their society; or when the public support male privilege values.

Theoretical contributions

Our research makes several theoretical contributions to the existing literature. Firstly, while previous studies have established work–life orientation as a significant dimension characterizing CEO communication on microblogs (e.g. Huang and Yeo, 2018; Jameson, 2014; Wu *et al.*, 2022), the influence of content orientation on public reactions remains understudied. By investigating the relationship between content orientation, gender roles and public engagement, our study provides a better understanding of corporate leaders' communication and emphasizes the importance of both content (i.e. work vs life-related) and communicator gender in the context of social media.

Secondly, we contribute to the discussion on leadership by incorporating gender roles and offering novel insights into gender research in leadership communication. Although recent research suggests that gender associations with communal/agentic characteristics have limited influence on the evaluation of top-level leadership, these associations continue to be influential in CEO communication with the public (Paustian-Underdahl, Walker and Woehr, 2014; Rosette and Tost, 2010; Rule and Ambady, 2009; Schaumberg and Flynn, 2017). Our research further supports this line of inquiry by demonstrating that the association of women with domestic activities and men with bread-winning work, which underlies gender-stereotypical beliefs, can impact the public's response to communications from female and male CEOs.

Moreover, our study enriches current gender research in social media communication by exploring the traditional gender role-incongruent content as a driver of public engagement. Unlike previous studies focusing on gender congruity between individuals (e.g. consumer gender and robot gender, consumer gender and anthropomorphized product gender) as a behavioural determinant (Hende and Mugge, 2014; Pitardi *et al.*, 2022), we investigate the effect of incongruity between communication content and communicator gender. This provides novel insights into gender research and highlights the importance of considering the congruence/incongruence between communication content and communicator gender.

Additionally, our research advances the understanding of gender roles and their impact on CEO communication by introducing a more nuanced and flexible perspective that encourages cross-gender exploration. While the existing corporate communication literature

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frequently explores masculine versus feminine leadership styles (e.g. Feenstra *et al.*, 2023; Jongen, 2024), our study highlights the importance of considering gender fluidity in leadership communication. Rather than strictly adhering to traditional gender norms, we propose that female CEOs focusing on work-related content and male CEOs engaging in life-related content can be viewed as forms of gender exploration. This new perspective invites a re-evaluation of the traditional binary understanding of gender roles and promotes a more inclusive approach to examining CEO communication.

Thirdly, we investigate the underlying mechanisms and boundary conditions of the phenomenon by drawing on the literature on schema congruity and gender egalitarianism. We find that traditional gender role-incongruent content from CEOs can lead to greater perceived novelty and heightened interest, ultimately enhancing engagement. However, such an effect would be diminished when the public perceives a very high or very low level of GEP, or when they hold male privilege GEVs. Interestingly, we also observe that people may acknowledge the novelty of a female (or male) CEO focusing more on work (or life), but this does not generate interest or engagement among individuals who perceive very low GEP or hold male-privilege GEVs. By taking into account GEP and GEVs, our research integrates diversity and inclusion aspects into the schema-congruity theory. It suggests that the public's response is not solely influenced by congruity or novelty of the message, but also by broader societal and cultural factors such as gender-equality and gender-role perceptions. This opens new avenues for applying schema-congruity theory to societal issues, an area that is currently under-explored in the literature.

Overall, our study provides insights into the potential drivers of engagement and expands the scope of schema-congruity theory and gender egalitarianism to encompass corporate leadership social media communication.

Managerial implications

Our research finds CEO gender to be an important moderator of the relationship between content orientation and public engagement on microblogs. Given the substantial increase in the number of women assuming top positions in organizations (Pew Research Center, 2015), our research findings provide useful guidance for CEOs and corporate communication professionals.

In particular, to engage the public, female executives can post content related more to their work, such as business insights, advice on leadership, daily work activities, business trips, corporate events, products and services; whereas male CEOs can post more about their personal life, such as leisure, hobbies, family, friends, seasonal greetings, daily life activities and reflections.

Organizations may consider investing in providing their CEOs, regardless of gender, with training and development that focuses on effective social media communication. This could involve building their capacity to deliver both work and life-related content effectively, permitting them to adjust their strategies to different contexts and audience groups.

Note that the above content strategy works best for audiences who perceive a moderate level of GEP in their society (very likely in countries with moderate gender-equality scores), or for audiences which do not support male-privilege values (very likely female or young individuals). Therefore, we suggest communication professionals check the country's gender-equality index to gauge the practice in the target market, as well as their target audience's general attitudes towards gender-equality issues before advising CEOs to adopt the content strategies proposed in the paper. Communication professionals might find it beneficial to use data mining with artificial intelligence to provide deeper insights into the target audience's engagements and attitudes about gender roles – empowering CEOs to tailor their content more engagingly.

Limitations

Our study has several limitations that provide valuable insights into the boundaries of our research. Firstly, it is important to acknowledge that our investigation primarily focuses on the work–life content orientation dimension in CEO microblog communication and its interaction with CEO gender. While this dimension provides valuable insights, other dimensions of CEO microblogging – such as language formality, expressed emotions and the degree of effort made by the CEO to interact with their audience on microblogs – have not been explored extensively.

Secondly, our research mainly emphasizes the participation aspect of public engagement in relation to CEO microblog communication, aligning with prevalent social media metrics. However, we have not extensively explored the cognitive and affective aspects of engagement with social media. To this end, our study may not fully capture the broader range of processes of public reactions.

Thirdly, the generalizability of our findings may be limited due to the primary use of Weibo, the prominent microblogging site in China, as the main data-collection platform. Although we manipulated participants' GEP and GEVs in Studies 4 and 5, it is important to acknowledge that extending our research to other microblogging service sites, such as X (formerly Twitter), would enable validation of our findings across diverse cultures, which potentially yield greater variance in GEP and GEVs.

Lastly, it is important to note that our study primarily focuses on the microblogging context and does not

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explore the role of other media context in shaping our findings. Contextual factors, such as traditional media, might impact the public's perception and reactions differently compared to microblogging platforms.

Future research

Building upon our research, we have identified several opportunities for future investigation. Firstly, future research could explore additional dimensions of CEO microblogging beyond the work–life content orientation. Investigating dimensions such as language formality, expressed emotions and CEO–audience interaction could provide a deeper understanding of how these elements influence the public's reactions when combined with content orientation.

Secondly, there is an opportunity to further investigate the cognitive and affective aspects of public engagement with CEO microblog communication. For example, sentiment analysis of comments could reveal how users respond to CEOs' Weibo content conditional on CEO gender.

Thirdly, future research should consider cross-platform and cross-cultural validation. Replicating and validating our findings on microblogging platforms other than Weibo, and among samples from diverse cultural backgrounds, would enhance the generalizability of our results.

Lastly, exploring the role of media context in shaping public reactions is an intriguing avenue for future research. Investigating how factors such as the distinction between social media and traditional media impact public perceptions and reactions would provide a more nuanced understanding of the interplay between CEO gender, content orientation and public reactions. Our provisional expectation is that our results would hold in social media contexts where novelty is highly valued; while in traditional media contexts, role congruity rather than incongruity might be more appreciated.

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